Last updated: October 13, 2026

Annica Wattler

Doctoral Candidate
Department of Economics, University of Bayreuth

Email: annica.wattler@uni-bayreuth.de
Websites: Personal Website · University Profile

Research Interests

Main: Development Economics, Gender Economics
Further: Labour Economics, Economics of Education, Health Economics
Methods: Applied Microeconometrics, Policy Evaluation

References

- David Stadelmann (Supervisor), University of Bayreuth (david.stadelmann@uni-bayreuth.de)
- Katja Kaufmann, University of Bayreuth (katja.kaufmann@uni-bayreuth.de)
- Djiby Thiam, University of Cape Town (djiby.thiam@uct.ac.za)
- Cristina Bellés-Obrero, IAE-CSIC & Barcelona School of Economics (cristina.belles@iae.csic.es)

Education

Ph.D. in Economics, University of Bayreuth (Bayreuth, Germany) 2023–present

- Expected completion (Dr. rer. pol.): 05/2027
- Working title: "Socio-Economic Development, Education and Living Standards: New Evidence and Perspectives from the Global South"
- Supervisor: Prof. Dr. David Stadelmann

M.A. Development Studies, University of Bayreuth (Bayreuth, Germany) 2020–2022

- Individual Focus: International Development Economics
- Thesis: "The effect of multi-faceted training programmes on the socio-economic status of young females: New evidence from Ghana"
- Supervisors: Prof. Dr. David Stadelmann, Dr. Raymond Frempong
- Final Grade: Very Good (1.1; German scale 1.0–5.0, 1.0 = best)

Exchange Semester, Nelson Mandela University (Gqeberha, South Africa) 2019

- Courses in Development Economics and Development Studies

B.Sc. International Business, ESB Business School (Reutlingen, Germany) 2016–2020

- Final Grade: Very Good (1.5)

Job Market Paper

Beyond Average Effects: The Uneven Promise of Child Marriage Bans (*Current Version*)

Abstract: Child marriage remains widespread even though most countries have adopted a legal minimum marriage age of 18. Previous studies find that reforms rarely delay marriage on average, but evidence on how their effects vary across contexts and how they affect women's life-cycle outcomes remains limited. I estimate causal effects of child marriage bans (CMBs), reforms setting 18 as the minimum age without parental-consent exceptions, combining WORLD policy data with Demographic and Health Surveys from 20 countries that adopted a CMB between 1995 and 2023. Using a fuzzy regression discontinuity design based on birth-month eligibility, I show that CMBs can reinforce pre-existing social shifts but cannot independently alter well-established marital institutions. In particular, I find that while CMBs are not effective on average, they do reduce child marriage in countries where its initial prevalence was low, with weaker evidence of similar effects where adolescent fertility was low or the pre-reform legal age was close to 18, as well as among girls aged 16 and 17. Independent of marriage timing, CMBs also increase women's likelihood of marrying a more educated husband and reduce the justification of intimate partner violence.

Publications

Ex-Post Evaluations of Aid Projects: A Cost-Effective Approach
with David Stadelmann. *Journal of Development Studies*, 2025, doi:10.1080/00220388.2025.2489556
Short Abstract: Evaluating targeted aid projects is costly and time intensive, partly because identifying an adequate control group is difficult. We propose a cost-effective approach for ex-post evaluations, consisting of constructing a control group from existing secondary data, such as household surveys, that mirrors the treatment group. We validate the method using data from an educational programme in rural Ghana targeting marginalised, out-of-school adolescent women, a highly specific intervention typical of small-scale development initiatives. We show that accounting for the project's selection criteria is critical when building the control group, and that survey questions administered to the treatment group must match those in the secondary data to ensure comparability.

Working Papers

A Harmonised Evaluation of All Free Primary Education Policies in Sub-Saharan Africa: Impacts on Women's Reproductive Health
with David Stadelmann and Frederik Wild
Short Abstract: Free Primary Education (FPE) reforms have been widely employed to estimate a causal effect of schooling on women's reproductive health. Yet, reported effects are generally modest and sufficiently heterogeneous that zero average impacts cannot be ruled out. We provide the first region-wide evaluation of 24 FPE countries, applying a unified regression discontinuity framework with bias-corrected and honest inference to reconcile a fragmented evidence base. We document substantial heterogeneity in FPEs' educational effects with little evidence of robust average gains in schooling. Consistent with these findings, we find no robust effects on reproductive health or hypothesised mechanisms such as labour market participation.

Conferences & Seminar Presentations

European Economic Association (EEA) Annual Congress (Dublin, Ireland) 2026
International Conference on Development Economics (Rouen, France) 2026
Meeting of the European Public Choice Society (Madrid, Spain) 2026
Research Workshop Bavarian Graduate Program in Economics (Bamberg, Germany) 2026
Simposio de la Asociación Española de Economía (SAEe) (Barcelona, Spain) 2025
Bavarian PhD Workshop in Development Economics (Erlangen, Germany) 2025
Graduate Seminar in Economics, University of Bayreuth (Bayreuth, Germany) 2024, 2025, 2026
Co-organiser of the annual two-day seminar since 2025

Teaching Experience

Instructor, Seminar in Development Economics 2024–present

- Elective master's seminar, University of Bayreuth (Bayreuth, Germany)
- Independently designed and taught seminar on education and economic development

Instructor, Introduction to Macroeconomics (Practical Sessions) 2023–present

- Required master's course, University of Bayreuth (Bayreuth, Germany)
- Independently taught two-day block course complementing the lecture
- Topics include national accounting and market failures

Student Tutor, Business Mathematics (Bachelor's), ESB Business School 2017–2018

Graduate Training

Machine Learning, Bavarian Graduate Program in Economics (BGPE) 2026
Introduction to Coding, SheCodes (HTML, CSS, JavaScript, VS Code) 2025
Barcelona School of Economics Summer School 2024
Course: Regression Discontinuity Designs in Development Economics
Academic Writing, BGPE 2024
Advanced Econometrics, BGPE (Top 5, instructed by Jeffrey Wooldridge) 2023
Advanced Microeconomics, BGPE 2023

Scholarships & Awards

Doctoral Scholarship, German Academic Scholarship Foundation 2023–present
(Studienstiftung des deutschen Volkes)

Marianne-Plehn-Programm, Elite Network of Bavaria 2023–present
Provides funding for a 25% part-time position at a Bavarian university

GO Research Award, University of Bayreuth 2024
Best master's thesis on gender relations and roles from an intersectional perspective

Exposé Scholarship, German Academic Scholarship Foundation 2022–2023

Study Scholarship, German Academic Scholarship Foundation 2018–2022

Work Experience

Research

Doctoral Researcher, University of Bayreuth (Bayreuth, Germany) 2023–present
Chair of Economic Policy and Economic Development

Student Research Assistant, University of Bayreuth (Bayreuth, Germany) 2022
Cluster of Excellence Africa Multiple

Other Experience

Intern, ICDP Ghana (Eastern Region, Ghana) 2021
Main Project: Strategic Approaches to Girls' Education (STAGE)

Key Account Manager, Mobil ISC GmbH (Bayreuth, Germany) 2021–2022

Executive Assistant, Mobil ISC GmbH (Bayreuth, Germany) 2020–2021

Intern & Bachelor's Thesis Candidate, ElringKlinger China (Suzhou, China) 2019–2020

Intern & Working Student, ElringKlinger AG (Dettingen, Germany) 2018

Development Volunteer, Programa Abrazo (weltwärts) (Asunción, Paraguay) 2015–2016

Field Research Experience

Research Trip on Post-Colonial Development (Namibia) 2024
Sponsored by the German Academic Scholarship Foundation

- Engaged with local NGOs, media outlets, and business leaders to examine post-colonial development and institutional governance in Namibia.

Fieldwork Lead, Master's Thesis Survey (Eastern Region, Ghana) 2022

- Planned and executed a field survey in collaboration with a local NGO.
- Trained and supervised a local team of enumerators conducting over 250 structured interviews.

Skills

Statistical Software: R, Stata, SPSS
Data Management & Tools: Excel, LaTeX
Programming: HTML, CSS, JavaScript

Languages

- German (Native)
- English (C2)
- Spanish (C2)
- French (C1)
- Catalan (Currently enrolled in A2.2, passed A2.1 with 96%)
- Portuguese (A2)